Bimal Kaur Khalsa, widow of Indira Gandhi assassin Beant Singh, from Ropar, and Beant Singh's father Sucha Singh, from Bathinda—giving the bloc real leverage over a Centre relying on shifting alliances.

A Bloody Decade

Believing a settlement to be possible, the Chandra Shekhar government negotiated with the Mann faction, whose demands included removing Gill, whom the militants saw as the face of counter-insurgency. Delhi agreed, replacing him with Mangat. Talks collapsed after Mann sought UN intervention. Militants read Delhi's instability and Gill's absence as weakness, and escalated their attacks instead of retreating.

The insurgency's character shifted too, from attacks on security forces to targeting the families of police, judicial officers, civil servants and engineers on strategic projects. Twelve judicial officers were assassinated in Punjab between 1989 and 1993; in May 1992, militants shot dead judicial magistrate Prem Kumar Goel and his wife in Jagraon. Earlier, on July 23, 1990, militants led by Balwinder Singh Jatana assassinated BBMB (Bhakra Beas Management Board) chief engineer M.S. Sekhri and superintending engineer Avtar Singh Aulakh inside their Chandigarh office, explicitly to halt construction of the Sutlej-Yamuna Link canal—a project that still awaits completion more than three decades later.

In his 1999 book, *Endgame in Punjab*, Gill notes that the militants began threatening police personnel to resign or see their families killed: 134 kin of police were murdered in 1991, more than 200 in 1992. The most notorious such attack came on the night of August 9, 1992, when militants raided three villages in Barnala district, killing 21 people, most of them police relatives—14 dragged from their homes and executed in Bakhatgarh village alone, in what was widely seen as retaliation for the police killing of Babbar Khalsa chief Sukhdev Singh Babbar earlier that day.

Alongside the targeted killing of Hindus on trains and buses, the decade after Operation Bluestar—1984 to 1994—saw the writ of Khalistani terrorist outfits expanded, causing the near-complete collapse of civil administration, the lower judiciary and the

PUNJAB'S DECADE OF DARKNESS

Operation Bluestar in June 1984, Prime Minister Indira Gandhi's assassination later that year on October 31, followed by the anti–Sikh massacres, created a powerful sense of grievance, which fed militant recruitment. What followed was a decade in which separatist terrorism, collapsing civil authority and a ruthless counterinsurgency claimed thousands of lives. The highlights:

JULY 1985: The Rajiv–Longowal Accord appears to offer an exit from the conflict. But Akali leader Harchand Singh Longowal is assassinated a month after, and key promises remain unfulfilled

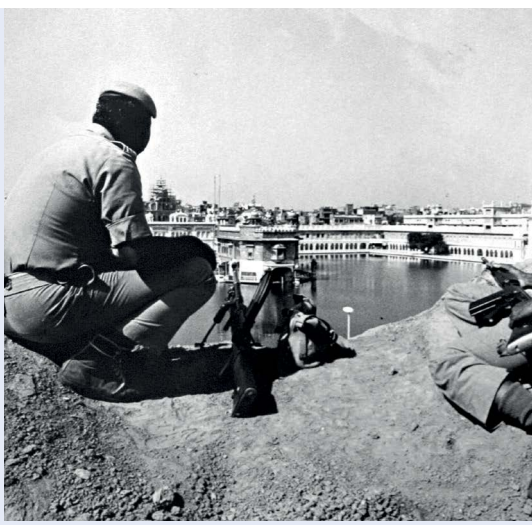
APRIL 1986: A Sarbat Khalsa gathering at the Akal Takht proclaims Khalistan as its aim. The Khalistan Commando Force, Babbar Khalsa, the Khalistan Liberation Force (KLF) and the Bhindranwale Tiger Force soon emerge

JULY, NOVEMEBER 1986: Extremist violence escalates, now with a clearer aim of communal retribution. In July and November, militants stop buses near Muktsar and Hoshiarpur, separate Hindu passengers and shoot them, killing 38 people in all, including one Sikh

MAY 11, 1987: The Barnala government is dismissed and President's Rule imposed. Militants control the countryside after dark; civil administration, judiciary and media retreat. The surgeon son of soon-to-be-DGP D.S. Mangat is murdered in Patiala

JULY 6, 1987: Militants attack a bus carrying Hindu pilgrims to Rishikesh, killing 38

MAY 1988: Over 200 armed militants again occupy the Golden Temple complex. Unlike Bluestar, Op. Black Thunder II avoids a direct military assault. Security forces led by Punjab DGP K.P.S. Gill sur-





PRAMOD PUSHKARNA